



Lexmark X215

THE WORKGROUP MFDs

MFDs with a monthly duty cycle of more than 15,000 were placed in this category, with the exception of the Samsung SCX-4720F, which has a duty cycle of 15,000. It was placed here because of its higher price and better feature set. Along with three MFDs from Brother, this category comprised four devices.

Features

As far as print resolution is concerned, the Brother DCP-8040 and MFC-8440 supported a maximum of 1200 x 600 dpi. The lowest in the category was the Brother MFC-8220, at 300 x 600 dpi. All MFDs had an input paper tray capacity of 250 sheets and an ADF tray capacity of 50, with the exception of MFC-8220, whose ADF held 30 sheets. All MFDs supported additional input paper trays. An additional input tray is a bonus, and is useful in the workgroup MFD category.

Since an MFD in this category will be subject to a large workload, it's a good thing if it has a higher duty cycle. All the Brother MFDs boasted of a monthly duty cycle of 20,000 pages—considerably higher than that of the Samsung SCX-4720F, which trailed behind at 15,000.

The Samsung had a toner duty cycle of 5,000 pages while the Brother MFDs lagged behind at 3,300. However, the Samsung's toner cartridge was priced considerably higher at Rs 6,999, whereas those of the Brother MFDs were priced at Rs 3,030. The cost per paper of the Brother MFDs was, therefore, lower at Rs 0.91, while that of the Samsung was Rs 1.40. The cost per page of the Brother MFDs is too low to ignore, since it is 50 per cent lower than that of the Samsung as per the rated toner duty cycle.

Brother's DCP-8040 and MFC-8440 supported a highest optical scanning resolution of 600 x 2400 dpi, while the MFC-8220 could not do more than 300 x 600 dpi, which is lower than even that supported by the MFDs in the SoHo segment.

When it came to interpolated scanning resolution, the Brother MFDs supported 9600 x 9600 dpi, while Samsung's SCX-4720F was restricted at 4800 x 4800.

The Samsung SCX-4720F sported only a flatbed scanner, and the Brother MFC-8220 had only a sheetfed scanner. The MFC-8440 and DCP-

8040 came with a sheetfed and a flatbed scanner.

A sheetfed scanner is useful when scanning documents longer than the conventional A4 size. We were surprised to find that the MFC-8220 supported only grayscale scanning, unlike the others, which supported 24-bit. All the Brother MFDs had a CIS scanning element, while the Samsung had a CCD element. As mentioned earlier, a CCD element is better than a CIS.

Only the Samsung SCX-4720F supported the 'scan to USB Flash drive' and 'print from USB Flash drive' features, where you can connect a USB Flash drive to the USB port on the MFD. You can then scan a document and save it to the USB drive as a BMP, TIFF or PDF file. You can also print a PRN, TXT, TIFF or BMP file from the USB drive without having to connect to a PC. This feature is helpful when, say, you need to scan a document, convert it to PDF and mail it to a client.

As far as copying goes, all scanners had similar features like standalone copying, reduce or enlarge, and up to 99 copies in multiple-copying mode. We think this is a bit low for the workgroup segment, though.

All the four MFDs had a Fax unit with the exception of the Brother DCP-8040. The Brother MFDs had memory that could hold 600 Fax pages, whereas the SCX-8720F could hold only 320 pages. This memory enables the unit to receive faxes and hold the pages even when in Standby mode.

The Brother MFC-8220 came with a handset for the Fax; a welcome feature.

In miscellaneous features, all MFDs with the exception of the Brother MFC-8220 had the option of adding a network module. All of them also had USB2.0 as well as a parallel interface. They all had 32 MB of buffer memory, which isn't really enough. But this issue is addressed by the memory upgradeability, which was available in all four MFDs.

The Samsung MFD supported Windows and Linux, while the Brother MFDs supported Windows and Mac. All of them came with quick-start guides and manuals (Samsung came with the manual on CD). The Samsung came bundled with AnyPage OCR, whereas the Brother MFDs came with OmniPage OCR software.

Power cables and USB cables were provided with the Samsung MFD. The Brother MFDs shipped without either.

The SCX-4720F was the heaviest of the four at



Brother MFC-8440